

■ By Elora Sen

The death of 65-year-old Hil Da Nirtiang was cataclysmic. Not only for her family but for the 8,000-strong Pnar tribe in the Jaintia Hills of Meghalaya as well, which forsook tradition in favour of Ka Khnap-Thangbru, a modern, eco-friendly crematorium designed by an unlettered 69-year-old in

keeping THE FLAME

✱ **Kambel Chulai, 69**
Project A low-cost crematorium which can be used anywhere as it runs on firewood

Inspiration 'Trekirod' or God, as they say in Jowai

Instead of Rs 5,000, the crematorium uses just **Rs 200** worth of wood to cremate a body



SUVASHIS MULLICK

Jowai. For his clan, Kambel Chulai is something of a genius who, without any formal training and hardly any education, has always been "inventing" things. In the far eastern, rain-soaked, remote corner of India, he goes about his work without waiting for government recognition or awards.

What is so unique about Ka Khnap-Thangbru, the crematorium that Chulai has designed? Compared to the traditional method, it is a permanent structure and consumes much less wood to burn a body. There is no need for electricity, and that can be a boon for rural India where in most places dead bodies are burned in the open, causing ecological havoc.

The lean and tall Chulai was almost bedridden till the age of 21 with various ailments. He could only attend school till Class III and knows just a few words of Hindi. But the very functionality of things he has invented belies his lack of formal training. He has dabbled as a sculptor, artist, architect, jeweller, movie operator, auto mechanic, sewing machine mechanic, dramatist and architect/builder. One of his inventions is a camera made of cardboard that can take twice the number of photographs of a normal camera. The trick lies in the positioning of the lens. What's more, he has always trained and taught himself.

Growing up in the midst of the serene hills, he was always troubled by the way cremations took place among his tribe. In the traditional method, two fully-grown